

FAMILY BY family Mount Drvitt

We believe
families know
family best

Scoping & start-up report

November 2013

Developed with and for Mount Drvitt Families



Developed and driven by

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FAMILY BY family

We exist to
enable more
families to
thrive, not
just survive.



Mounty County

Since 2010, Family by Family has been working with families in South Australia. Now we have been given a great opportunity to work within Mount Druitt, City of Blacktown, Western Sydney.

In coming to Mount Druitt we never assumed that we could simply transfer the model from South Australia to Mount Druitt. Instead we believed we would need to spend time in the community, getting to know as much as we could about families, what's tough, what they care about and what they aspire to.

The methodology that we apply to do this, we call scoping. Scoping doesn't aim to reinvent the model in each new area, but to reshape it so that Family by Family is a truly local network of families helping families move towards thriving.

Understanding local families is the first stage of scoping. Over the past 2 months we've run or been involved in 7 pop up stalls, met over 60 families in Mount Druitt, and hung out with 25 of these families in their homes and in the community or spent whole days with them. A big part of our scoping has also been learning about services and what they do for the community, through a lunch with services we met 45 service providers, and then did 26 service visits.

In scoping Mount Druitt, we have also thought about how our learnings can inform the larger service system. Through using ethnographic and co-design methods, Family by Family can inform the system on how to localise and create person-centred services. There is much that Mount Druitt families have experienced and have to say, that can help all services to better respond to families.

We've heard that Mount Druitt is known for being a tough place having high needs and a bad reputation. Though aspects of this are true, we were inspired by the people, their community, their hope for something else, and their willingness to help others to get there.

This report is the story of the families and services we've met, and what we've learned from them. We will be adapting the Family by Family model to fit Mount Druitt and thinking about the bigger picture.

What's in this report?

What's FAMILY BY family?

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Here we give a brief recap on the 5 parts of the Family by Family model.

What gets adapted?

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Here we talk about the core features of Family by Family and the features we expect to adapt in different areas.

What is scoping?

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FAMILY BY family for Mount Druitt

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Here we answer the 5 scoping questions and show how we plan to adapt Family by Family for Mount Druitt.

Start-up in Mount Druitt

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Here we set out our work so far in Mount Druitt and our plans for the near future.

More Mount Druitt families

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At the end of the report, we include heaps more stories from families we met in Mount Druitt.



What's FAMILY BY family?

(before Mount Druitt)



1

Finding families

We meet families through pop-up events at parks, shopping centres, schools and child care centres. We find two kinds of families. Sharing Families who have come through tough times and want to help others, and Seeking Families who want to change something in their family. Wanting to change is our only criteria for Seeking Families.

2

Training families

We run whole family camps and top-up training experiences to enable Sharing Families - kids included - to build the Sharing Family strengths.

3

Link-ups

Sharing Families volunteer their time to link-up with Seeking Families and help them work towards their goals, e.g. getting out of the house more, having better friends or improving behaviour.

The families meet at least once a week for 10 to 30 weeks. The length of time of link-ups is flexible - based on individual family needs.

The first part of a link-up focuses on building a relationship, the second part on the families doing things together, and the third part on supporting Seeking Families to build their connections in the community that will help them sustain their goals without the support of Sharing Families.



4

Coaching

During a link-up, Seeking and Sharing Families receive support and guidance from their local Family Coach.

Sharing Families are reimbursed for regular coaching and engage in ongoing peer learning.



5

Measurement

At the middle and end of a link-up, families measure changes in progress towards their self set goals.

Two weeks after a link-up has ended, we carry out an independent evaluation of link-ups to find out about the change they created and how we can continue to improve the model.



6

Working with services

Throughout our process, we continually seek to learn from other services, meet new families, and find ways to share our learnings, through shadowing and regular service lunches.

Our premise is simple: families who have come through tough times can help others move towards thriving

Our premise comes from spending hundreds of hours with families across

South Australia. Comparing families who were thriving with those who were struggling helped us to see that 'thriving' wasn't about how much money families had, or how families were structured, or where families lived. Nor was thriving about luck or circumstance.

Thriving families had been through their fair share of tough times - depression, teenage motherhood, domestic violence, family breakdown, joblessness, etc.

What differentiated thriving families from struggling families were their behaviours & support networks. Thriving families set goals; tried new things as a family; encouraged each other; and did developmental things outside the house.

Thriving families learned these behaviours, not from formal services, but from other families around them. They had strong informal relationships that motivated and supported them through ups and downs.

What gets adapted for different locations?

1 Finding families

2 Training families

3 Link-ups

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
We don't have any eligibility criteria for Seeking Families other than the desire to change something in their family	We expect to change when and where recruitment happens
We use the following key messages in recruiting families - "We're families helping families. We're not religious, political or government"	We expect to change the look and feel of family-facing materials used for recruitment
We use developmental experiences and family friendly materials to recruit families	We expect to develop unique local offers

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
We use observational methods to identify families who can model thriving behaviours and gain the Sharing Family strengths	We expect to change the range of methods used to identify & invite potential Sharing Families
We use immersive training experiences for the whole family to further develop the Sharing Family strengths	We expect to change the style of training experiences to accommodate different kinds of families & learning styles
We use regular, top-up training experiences for the whole family that reinforce the Sharing Family strengths over time	We expect to change the content of top-up training experiences based on emergent issues and needs

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
Seeking Families choose which family to link-up with using Sharing Family profiles	We expect to change the look and feel of profiles; information shared on profiles
Seeking Families choose the goal of their link-up using a tool called the bubble diagram	We expect to roll out and test a new format for the bubble diagram using an iPad
Seeking and Sharing Families meet at least three hours every week for a minimum of 10 weeks. More is encouraged	We may increase the duration and intensity of link-ups for different kinds of families
Coaches check-in with Seeking and Sharing families and measure progress at the middle and end of link-ups	We may increase the number of check-ins for different kinds of families

Family life is different in different areas, so we adapt family by family for different communities

Before Family by Family can start, we need to attract & engage families. What attracts and engages families varies by community, based on an areas activities, services, cultural traditions, social norms and infrastructure.

Scoping projects are about understanding this local context, and working with families to reshape Family by Family so they take some ownership over the network & experience change. Scoping projects are not about discarding what's core to the Family by Family model.

There's a healthy literature¹ about how to adapt social programs so they fit local contexts. Most efforts to adapt social programs end up compromising their effectiveness. That's because they are adapted with low fidelity - meaning the core components are somehow weakened or forgotten. Researchers who study program replication talk about 'acceptable' versus 'risky' adaptations.

Acceptable adaptations

- Changing language & look
- Changing cultural & social references
- Changes to address local barriers (e.g. transportation)
- Adding evidence-based interactions

Risky adaptations

- Changing the underlying premise
- Changing the theory of change
- Reducing the time & intensity
- Changing key messages & topics
- Reducing training & support
- Using fewer staff



Coaching



Measurement



Working with services

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
Family Coaches & Kids Coaches troubleshoot & support families, rather than drive change	We may increase the number of Kids Coaches given large numbers of children
Sharing Families attend weekly coaching sessions to gain new skills	We expect to change where coaching occurs and the make up of coaching sessions
Attendance at coaching sessions is incentivised through a family payment	We may change the amount and form of the family payment
Sharing Families - including kids- provide regular peer-to-peer support	We may change when & where peer-to-peer support happens
Seeking Families attend at least two events over the course of a link-up where they meet and interact with other families	We may increase the number & structure of events to enable more interactions between families
Both Seeking and Sharing Families will leave the program at some point	We may add interactions to provide ongoing support for alumni of Family by Family

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
Families are measured against the goals they set at the middle and end of link-ups, using bubble diagram & stickers	We may change the format the measurement takes
Kids participate in measurement, where possible	We may change the format of measurement tools to enable kids of different ages to participate
Formal evaluation & co-design session held after a link-up ends	We may change the look and feel of evaluation sessions, and how we use feedback

Core features...	Likely adaptations...
Staff meet and engage with a wide range of services	We may seek out opportunities to form new partnerships or contribute towards a localisation strategy

FAMILY BY family

Our scoping
project set
out to answer
5 questions.



Question 1:

What's family like in Mount Druitt?

Question 2:

How does community work in Mount Druitt?

Question 3:

What are services like in Mount Druitt?

Question 4:

What can we learn from the eco system in which services operate?

Question 5:

Given all this learning, how can we best adapt family by family for Mount Druitt?

What is the scoping process?

Meeting families

Getting to know families

Shadowing services



We joined a family BBQ day and ran a free raffle

We set up stalls at locally run family fun days

We took part in activities run by the Aboriginal community

We attended neighbourhood events, like breakfasts and craft groups

We visited local playgroups and services

We had conversations with 60 families

We spent time, having dinner, sometimes full days, with 25 families

We used a series of tools and visual prompts to get feedback and a notebook to write up the responses

We hosted a services lunch for 45 services providers

We attended a number of inter-agency meetings

We dropped in on services to share who we were and learn about them; we spent more time with some

We collected program materials and observed the user experience

We reflected on differences and similarities with Family by Family

Analysing

Adapting

Scoping projects draw on the same kinds of methods used to develop Family by Family

To answer the 5 scoping questions, we use the same kinds of co-design methods used to develop Family by Family.

Ethnographic methods - or hanging out with people - enable us to understand the context in which Family by Family will sit; in other words, what is competing for the family's attention, what are they motivated by, what are they turned off by, and what are the barriers to engagement?

Co-design methods - or brainstorming ideas & visualising alternatives - help us gauge reactions to concepts and come up with a better way of doing things. Families are part of the idea generation process, and gain ownership over the end result.

Adapting - or trying out our new ideas in real time - helps us learn what families in Mount Druitt will actually engage with, and what they won't.



We wrote-up ethnographies

We'll test our new messaging and materials

We highlighted key themes, and grouped families to explore patterns

We'll try new spots for our recruitment

We generated ideas for how to improve materials & interactions

We'll add new pictures and text to our flyer

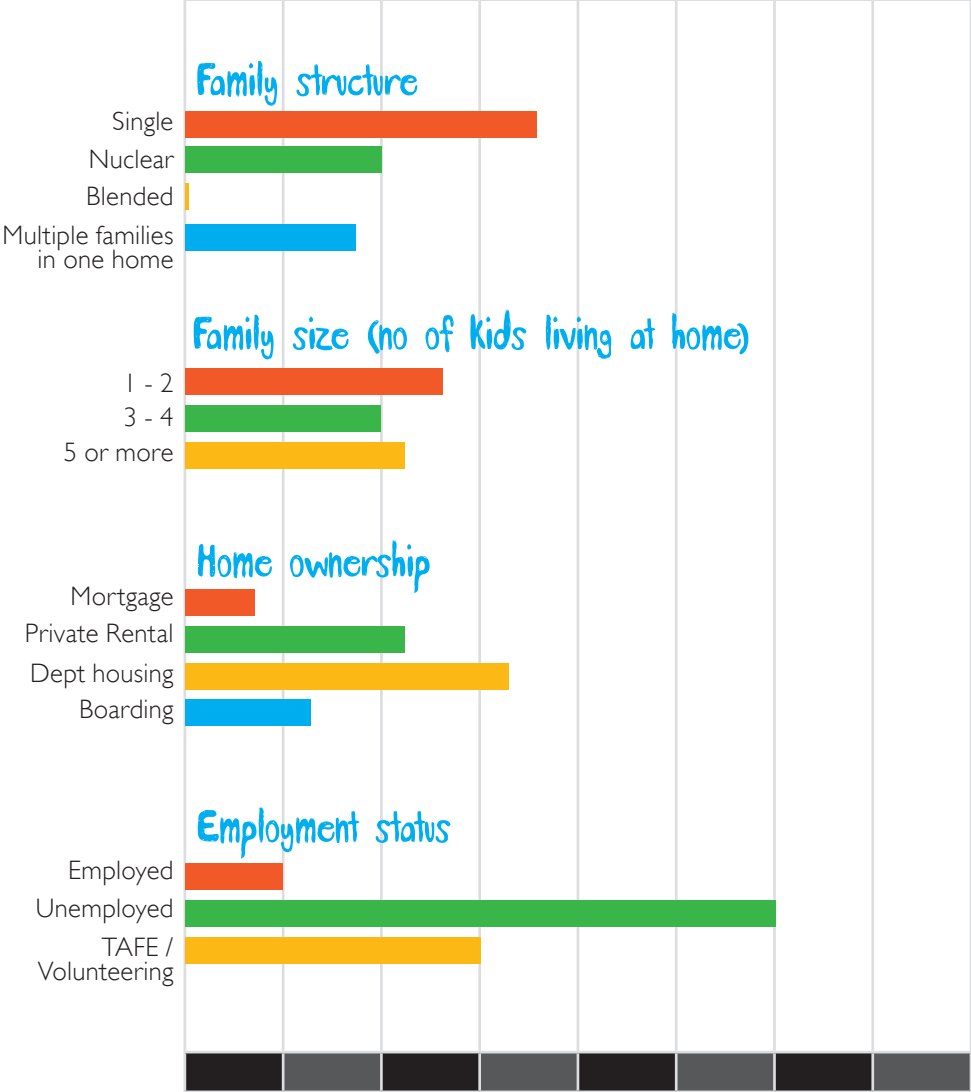
We'll run more dinners with potential Sharing Families to improve the offer and materials

We'll run a small version of our sharing camp to test training materials with potential Sharing Families. We might change the order of events

Who did We meet?



We got to know 25 families in Mount Druitt



We met heaps of different kinds of families

We met families of all shapes, sizes, and cultures by setting up pop-up stalls at family fun days, and going out to community groups and services.

We told families we were a new network of families, and that we wanted to understand their experiences as a family in Mount Druitt and get their feedback on some early ideas.

Once we started spending time with families, we quickly learned how little, labels like 'single-parent' or 'unemployed', told us about the family. More instructive was hearing about where families wanted to be, what they had been through, and observing how they interacted with each other.

4 family stories



Tales from four of the families we met to show the diversity of the community and how different family experiences can be

Find more family stories on p38

Family details anonymised

The Vindal's

An Aboriginal Family

Merinda lives alone in her housing commission home with her cat, although she does have two children. Her 9 year old son's behaviour had become too stressful, **"coming home with an attitude, being disrespectful, taking off all the time with his bum arse mates."** He's been sent to live with his Dad on the North Coast **"so he can have a go at him now."** Her 3 year old daughter was living with her sister, but has recently been removed by DOC's. Merinda's trying to find out how she's going, but because it happened in another area, she's finding it difficult.

Who's around and who's helpful?

Merinda loves it in Mount Druitt and has strong community connections. Some programs specifically for Indigenous people have been 'great', like the Aboriginal Co-operation for legal and health advice, and vouchers. Usually we'd find her as an active participant in programs run by a local church where she's 'part of the furniture', or taking part in outreach, as she loves to learn. She shares her most recent project from a TAFE course - a bag decorated with patchworks of meaningful sayings like 'sorry don't mean shit when our people are still suffering'. She's no passive observer and describes herself as a 'networker' - it's important that she takes part in things where she can share what her community is all about, what they need and what they are trying to do - **"so people can understand what's around here and what we've got for ourselves and our kids."**

Less helpful are some of her neighbours. She's had trouble with one in particular and experiences verbal abuse like **"you black this ... you black that."** She holds her head up high and tries not to let it get to her.

She thinks they may have broken into her house when she left recently to bury her sister - the washing machine 'grew legs and walked', and her door was boarded up when she came back.

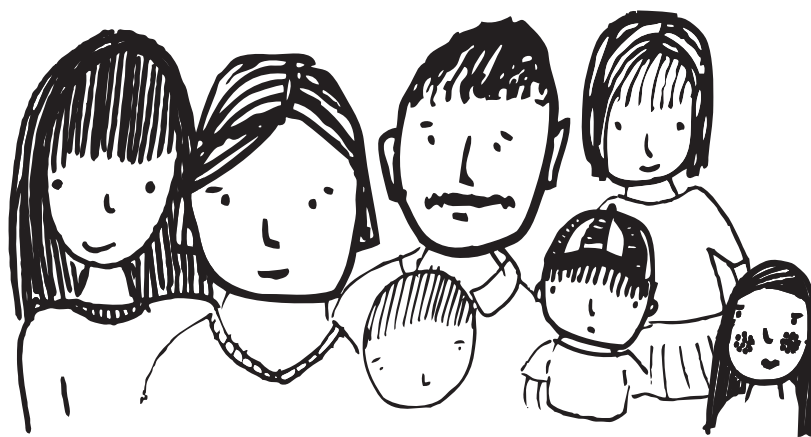
What's tough?

Merinda suffered domestic violence, and tells us this is still a problem for some of her wider family, along with alcohol abuse, ill health and a recent stabbing. Sometimes she feels like she doesn't know if she is coming or going and worries that all of her sisters are on the verge of a nervous breakdown. She managing to hold it together to be strong for them. She's sad about recent deaths of both her brother and sister and feels stressed that her mum and dad are also both unwell and currently in separate hospitals. Walking helps to 'clear her head' from all the negative 'thinking thinking'. She tells us: **"you need to pull through. You have to."**

What do they want for their lives?

Merinda is passionate about wanting better things for young people in the area, **"both Indigenous and non Indigenous as there's nothing round here for them to do."** She believes many young people join gangs out of boredom and peer pressure. She wants to put a stop to that.

She sees opportunities to pull together with all different kinds of people and services to really make a difference and has lots of ideas about how things could be better for the neighbourhood. She wants to be someone who will always help out others to get back on their feet if needed: **"Black, white, yellow or purple. If someone needs a hand and they are down and out... I end up taking them in and giving them a roof over their heads."**



The Leota's

A Pacific Islander Family

We meet Mana together with her mother Loto (meaning 'heart') in her privately rented home full of family photo's and glimpses of a full, communal life. 3 of her 4 children whizz in and out every now and then from piano practice, eating pizza and playing on their bikes on the streets. Her partner and her father have stayed away, described as 'men of few words' who leave the family organising to their wives, with Loto very much the matriarch, but we're told they can be relied upon when there is a need.

Who's around and who's helpful?

Close family and friends can be found in each suburb, too many to map and mention. They love the area and think the media is responsible for its negative publicity: **"It's not even bad. And everywhere has 'bad', and nothing here is really stressful. It's what you make of it."**

The extended family is a big part of this family's life and the support they give is recognised as a key factor in their wellbeing too. So to is their relationship with the church, with time given for daily worship and weekend activities relating to their faith. They are, however, keen to point out that they would never force their religion on anyone.

Engaging and building their community is also important. As well as their church work, they have been instrumental in setting up local initiatives to help build respect and a wider sense of possibility in their neighbourhood. Their vision was to support the young people to see another side of life, **"not just police banging on your doors, or smoking and drinking. Something different."** They have set up

an afternoon kid's club offering tutoring and activities, and a breakfast gathering twice a week. They are now seeing parents and older residents join in and believe there is more connection in the community as a result: **"It's more like seeing each other as friends and family. We care for and want the best for each other too."**

What's tough?

It was a struggle to get this family to identify what causes them stress. For them, there was nothing that couldn't eventually be worked through or be accepted, switched off, or moved on from. Mana reluctantly tells us that relationships sometimes caused worry, but shared strategies like **"don't let the sun come down without saying sorry"** or picking a time 'once everything is smooth' to talk through issues, rather than disagreeing while issues were raw. The 'Services' card was picked out, but not from their own negative experiences, but more from their belief that they saw services as not being relevant to the needs of whole families, or going deep enough to make a real impact in their community.

What do they want for their lives?

This family's love of learning is something they would like to see spread, specifically to other Pacific Islanders where they see the more traditional belief has been to work hard, but not **"using our brains"** or valuing getting qualifications. Mana is thinking about doing a Masters in Social Work that's being offered through a TAFE / Uni partnership especially for people residing in the western area. Although it's a struggle with HECs, she believes it will be worth it: **"You get a lot of old school families that just say, 'no, go to work, earn money'. But learning can help you get out of poverty basically."**



The Garland's

A really large household of families

It's a bulging household that acts as home to single parent Margaret and her 3 children. It belongs to her Dad Shane who also lives there. He bought it for \$69,000 20 years ago, but now owes \$200,000 due to the damage of two divorces, and needing to remortgage in order to make ends meet.

It's also shared by her brother, his two children (every weekend), her two sisters, one sister's boyfriend, the boyfriend's two children (every second weekend), a boarder, and a family friend. There's 11 in total at home every day, rising to 13 and 15 each respective weekend. It's also a habitat to 5 chickens, 4 cats, 3 rabbits and even a duck.

Who's around and who's helpful?

Dad Shane is the glue holding everyone together. He's currently renovating the garage as a granny flat for his son to move into, but until that's done, they need to share a bed. There is not enough bedroom space, so even the family room contains bunk beds. He's become skilled in spotting local food bargains. He needs to be. He drives to find the specials, and spends time adding up the supermarket rewards points for the best deals. He's also responsible for all the family's cooking.

You could say this is a family that acts as their own mini community. They need to be really organised to cope with the demands of living in such cramped conditions. In their free time,

they tend to stick together and stay at home, although one of Margaret's children enjoys gymnastics at the local community centre. As well as her work, Margaret volunteers every Friday at a local drop-in cafe.

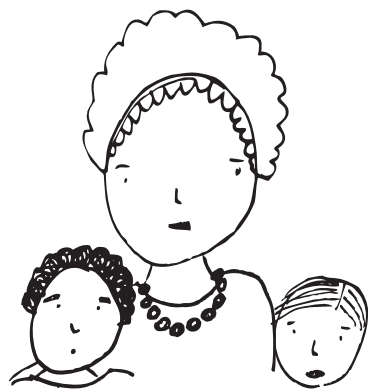
They liken Mount Druitt to Area 51 which is a 'no go zone' in America. Margaret tells us she's heard about people getting '2770' tattooed on themselves which is the Mount Druitt postcode. She said this is due to a sense of pride.

What's tough?

Money and space is a big struggle in a house of so many. Unresolved past traumas experienced by Margaret's family are affecting where they can get available housing.

What do they want for their lives?

Margaret's goal is to be in a different property by the start of the new year, despite the high costs of private rental and a lack of suitable ones on offer. There is also very little money left over for essentials like bonds or advances in rent. She would love to move back to Perth, but a court order means she needs to reside in NSW, and at least here she gets the support of her Dad.



The Varley's

A single parent family

Molly is a white Australian single mum of two boys, Daniel (aged 8) and Trevor (aged 3). She was in and out of a domestic violence relationship for 10 years, but got through it and has been separated now for 2 years with help from a domestic violence service. She says **"the worker saved my life."** She attributes this to their patience and lack of judgement. She now facilitates a support group which includes craft and guest speakers.

Who's around and who's helpful?

As well as her involvement with the support group, Molly counts herself as lucky to get support from her Dad who comes over and brings McDonalds as a treat for dinner once a week. The kids love spending time with him. They also sometimes travel to see her brother, and she has a good friend who lives close by and who she often has a chat with once the children go to bed. For fun, they tend to go outside of Mount Druitt as, **"there's not a lot in the area."**

What's tough?

Surviving on Centrelink is tough for Molly but she tries to be creative with what they have. There is one neighbour that gives her cause for concern. Their teenage children swear, walk on the roofs and throw rocks at houses and cars out of boredom.

Working on lots of projects at the same time means she sometimes struggles to fit everything in but she loves setting and working towards goals.

What do they want for their lives?

"I'd like not to struggle, and for this to happen I need a good job." Molly sees her next steps as studying Community services, with a hope to work in the domestic and family violence field.

Molly has set up her own small business where people can donate anything and everything to support families experiencing or escaping domestic violence. She'd like to see it expand to allow her to help more people. She's proud that Daniel is doing so well at football and Molly wants to do all she can to support his growth in that. They are looking forward to a great Christmas and their home is already decorated beautifully with handmade paper chains and a large tree.

Molly loves the idea of being part of Family by Family and says, **"If I can walk the path with another family and it makes a difference in their life then that makes me happy, I'll make more friends too."**

Families in Mount Druitt

Family by Family has been designed with and for all families. Rather than ask the question: who is eligible for Family by Family? We ask the question: who is attracted to Family by Family? That leads us to group families in terms of their motivations and goals instead of their professionally assessed risks or needs. We find that 4 kinds of families are attracted to Family by Family.

Families in and out crisis:

These are families who have big ups and downs; the past is never far away, and they are constantly reacting to what's happened rather than planning forward. Often, their networks & relationships are pulling them in the wrong direction.

Stuck families:

These are families rooted in the present; there are so many stresses in the everyday that there's no space to think about the future. They expend most of their resources getting through the day, and they often lack networks around them to pull through the other side.

Families moving on:

These are families who have just come through some pretty tough stuff, are starting to think about the day after next, but have few resources or models for how to get there.

Families wanting more:

These are families who are actively setting goals, seeking out opportunities to work towards those goals, and open to anything that will help them move forwards.

Things We learned from families in Mount Druitt



Under the same roof

We were surprised how common it was to find multiple families living in the same home - sons bunking up with fathers, sisters, uncles, partners, boarders and even chickens in the one big household. Many had found useful ways to share roles and responsibilities, and had good strategies for being organised which we think we can learn from. Other talked about acting as their own 'community' with their homes as meeting places, rather than going out to things.

Under serviced

The word 'services' didn't resonate with many families, they thought we were talking about utilities like power. When we shared our services cards, many had heard of some, but didn't use them. Often they assumed they were for a family in a much worst situation than them, or just for times of crisis. Sometimes they had built a really good relationship with one particular service, and subsequently become reliant on them for all their needs. Some talked out about how some larger services were now located out of the area and this was too far for them to access. Others wanted more practical support than what was offered, and to be 'listened to, not lectured at'.

Stigma and judgement

Families had great things to say about Mount Druitt, but told us they struggled with the stigma of living somewhere with such a bad, unfair reputation. Many felt judged by others when they described living in the area, and felt the need to explain themselves. One family had resorted to giving other addresses and postcodes when applying for jobs believing disassociating with the area would help. Most families blamed the media for this negative portrayal, and acknowledged that while Mount Druitt had its problems, their experiences were not like what has been written.

Community spirit

Many families spoke of a sense of real community in the area. For them, things keep getting much better, and they're using their drive to raise the confidence and engagement of neighbours who previously sensed their life possibilities were rather restricted. Even in the so called 'bad areas', we found people and groups desperate for action and working hard to improve and reinvigorate their areas. Others were heavily involved with the church, through both worship and outreach programs, and enjoyed the connections this brought them.



Bored and nowhere to go

Many families picked up on that young people struggled to be engaged in the area, and that this was a problem - both from a lack of opportunities to help them develop as the next generation, but also that boredom was probably responsible for a noisy minority of teenagers causing issues. Likewise some families struggled to find ways to do things together here, beyond shopping. Apart from school and some groups, many families struggled to name opportunities where they could informally meet other families like them.

Melting pot

We got to meet with families with origins from all over the world in Mount Druitt. We were curious to learn from their distinctions and similarities; typically we found that every family is different. Still families had really specific ideas of things they thought would work for their culture and context. New ideas for messaging like 'we won't share your business or gossip' resonated. This fits with our learnings from a project we're developing in South Australia, looking at the notion of cultural adaptiveness through excellence in practice, and what the opportunities are for a program like Family by Family.

Learning to work

Many families we met were involved in further learning, like TAFE, or were volunteering to help out others. Often they saw this as being the first step to getting a job. However many didn't have a clear way of gaining other kinds of experience in their chosen industries. Many were studying without a clear pathway in terms of what they would do or strive for next.

Large families

We met with lots of large families, with four or more children. It was common to see both teenagers and pre-schoolers in the same house. This often meant that home life was hectic, as there were always several children in the house and looking for something to do. Families had ways of keeping kids occupied in the home, where items like large TVs and iPads were common, but very little was going on outdoors. Having such large families meant that money and transport difficulties often came up as the biggest issue.





FAMILY BY family A model for Mount Druitt

(5 scoping questions answered)

Question 1:

What's family like in Mount Druitt?

Understanding local families is the first stage of scoping. We hung out with families to learn about their routines and home life, and delved deeper into their interests, capabilities and values. We talked to them about what they want from their lives, where they see the good stuff happening, what's tough, and who's around and who's helpful for them. We wanted to understand what makes an effective Sharing Family in this context, and the things we would need to change to attract and support Seeking Families here.

We spent time with at least one family living in each of the 12 suburbs of Mount Druitt in order to learn from any neighbourhood differences. Where we might have expected more segregation, we discovered families of all shapes, sizes and origins in each.

Cultural diversity was also important to understand. From the 60 conversations, and the 25 families we were able to spend quality time with, we were lucky to learn from a rich mix of cultural backgrounds who had put down roots here.

From Pacific Islander families, we learnt about the importance of the church, of giving space to worship, and about a strong commitment to education, community and learning. The families we met struck us as having many thriving behaviours, from their focus on self development, and the way they brokered to experiences outside of family. Despite hearing about strong religious beliefs, they weren't put off by our 'we're not religious' messaging, and liked the idea that this would attract different kinds of families.

We were surprised by the high number of families who were volunteering or finding ways to help others. Likewise the many parents enrolled in TAFE and learning programs. This could be due to high unemployment, but many in this community didn't want to sit back and accept poor outcomes as inevitable, they were vocal and striving to make the community better. We have a hunch that becoming a Sharing Family could appeal to people wanting work experience or to build skills that could be immediately useful to their lives.

From Indigenous families, we saw lots of community engagement, and were reminded of the importance of confidentiality with 'family business'. This was also something that came up when visiting multiple families living in one home. It seems important that Sharing Families and Coaches will need to be more explicit about keeping family stories safe and private. Many shared their different ideas about the kinds of life they were after, and what it might take to get there.

We met many single Mums. Some described feeling stuck from the weight of unresolved past experiences, and now saw little prospect of change, despite prior counselling and emergency intervention. Others were trying to work out how to overcome the trauma they had experienced, but lacked the starting points to problem solve and move on. Mental health was often a prevailing issue. Sharing Families may need more training to help support this.

Many of the more stuck families felt they had no time, yet weren't able to acknowledge their hours in front of the television. Family by Family appealed because people saw it as something that could open up opportunities they previously hadn't thought of.

It was important to learn about what was tough. Families in Mount Druitt are forthright and frank in sharing their challenges, and patterns emerged around past hurts, lack of money, lack of work, and lack of opportunities to engage in. Children's behaviour and intergenerational family difficulties were issues families identified as needing support with - they hankered after better relationships, but were often at a loss to know how, particularly with such limited resources, and in some instances marked social isolation. The fact that Family by Family emphasises family led change for the whole family resonated.

Unaffordable rents and a shortage of properties meant some families were living together with other families and their wider families and friends in overcrowded homes. Many homes had communal areas and were making use of dining tables, however we saw many large backyards that weren't being used. Could Family by Family make use of these kinds of resources in people's homes?

Opportunities:

Tweak the offer: "Get linked-up with another family you decide on, gain work skills, find out free, good places for families."

Widen our snowballing recruitment campaign - include education providers, church leaders and neighbourhood 'connectors' to share food, learn about Family by Family, and spread the word.

Increase Sharing Family training around mental health and the need to keep family matters private

Consider the use of family resources and hold "micro events" from people's backyards

Question 2:

How does community work in Mount Druitt?



In this area of scoping we were seeking to understand the geography, culture and facilities in the community. We also wanted to understand the difference between perceptions and what it is really like on the ground. What is Mount Druitt really like for families?

Read the paper, or the strategically placed street signs, and Mount Druitt acts as a byword for violence and crime, notorious through scare stories of its drunks, drugs and depravity.

And yet this reality has little resemblance to the experiences we learnt from families living in the area. While certain 'sides' (we were told there was a good and bad part to each) of the suburbs were known to not be the safest or the most picturesque, the majority of families told us they liked living here and that the people made it so. Few shared their aspirations to live elsewhere, although some were wary to venture out at night, and wished for safety from the potential danger of strangers.

Misconducts brought up were often put down to a 'minority' - a random rogue neighbour, or the result of disenchanted youths hanging with the wrong crowd to relieve the boredom of no prospects and no places to go. We met teenagers who told us there was nothing for them to do, and yet they obviously had so much potential and lots to give. The prospect of being involved in something like Family by Family sounded interesting to them. Given the stories that families told us of poverty,

unemployment and past hurts, can we involve young people more to make a difference for family futures?

Many families went as far as sharing their vision of Mount Druitt as a place of possibility and potential, and were actively trying to build a strong sense of community spirit with their neighbours. Families we met saw others as worse off and wanted to do their bit to help out where they could: **"When you've lived somewhere so long, you just want to better it. And the only way we can do that is to see what we can give"**. Family by Family could work with these local role models to champion a vision around making 'Mount Druitt better'.

We heard about the work of outreach programs, such as those offered by TAFE, community halls and churches making big differences to the lives of the people who become involved with them. This was important because of the stories of social isolation we heard from some families. What worked well was when programs met families in places convenient for them, and didn't rely on them coming to their service.

Mount Druitt is a community of contrast. Smashed up furniture, shattered glass, boarded up shops covered in graffiti and burnt out cars are alongside community breakfasts, kids clubs, and free plant giveaways. While a state of the art community hub was opened in Mount Druitt in 2011, still the only place in Bidwill where locals can buy bread, milk and nappies remains the bottle shop.



Some families spoke about making use of the new Ropes Crossing community which boasts leafy boulevards, a brand spanking new community centre and pristine parks. Many felt the local Mount Druitt parks weren't safe and didn't use them, due to seeing needles and empty bottles lying around. Family by Family will need to connect with all parts of Mount Druitt and the surrounding area so we can help families see and experience the full picture of what's on offer here.

Other perceived barriers included unsafe public transport links (although some families who used it found it reliable), and expensive local activities that are designed for families, but unaffordable for many surviving literally on the bread line.

We also heard about some instances of racism, but they seemed to be based on a particular past experience or event, rather than an ingrained belief. One family told us **“you'd never be able to survive here in this community if you have a racist outlook.”** Similar to our work in South Australia, we will be working with both Coaches and Sharing Families to develop a culturally adaptive approach in their practice.

Opportunities

Try different hooks for Sharing Families: 'help out', 'build the community' or 'help make Mount Druitt better'

Give materials and interactions a local and culturally diverse emphasis to reflect families and landmarks from the area, 'local families from Mount Druitt helping local Mount Druitt families'

Increase our use of local parks and public spaces when running Family by Family events

Create materials that clearly explain Family by Family to young people to test the possibility of using them as a resource

Develop cultural adaptive training for Sharing Families

Question 3 & 4:

What are services like in Mount Druitt?
What can we learn from the eco system
they operate in?



In this area of scoping, we were looking to understand the service system in Mount Druitt in order to find out how services work together and how they work with families. We had heard that there were a lot of services already but that for some, client engagement had been problematic and achieving desired outcomes for families had been a longer and harder slog than expected.

In addition, one of our primary goals was to understand the services and people we are working with in order to complement their services with Family by Family.

What did we learn?

Hand up = better engagement Where some services did have high levels of client engagement, they were often described to us as places that gave clients a 'hands up; instead of 'hand outs'. Workers talked about the need to help the services move forward from this mentality. It was inspiring to meet some on the ground workers who were trying to challenge these notions.

Lots of services While there is a diverse set of services within Mount Druitt, and families accessed some of these, a number of the families did not have much knowledge about many of the services that would be most helpful or relevant to meeting their

needs. One family said,

"I thought I knew Mount Druitt well but after meeting you I realise there is a lot out there that I don't know about that I would like to try."

Great service connection Services appear to be very well connected with a number of inter-agency meetings. This was highlighted to us after our first visit where many of the services we called to make contact with already knew about us through an e-mail network, many actually said, ***"Oh, are you that service from Adelaide?"***

Before our initial set up in Mount Druitt, we had many local service providers contacting and emailing us their support. We find them a vibrant and passionate social sector who were generous in their time and support of us.

The inter-agency meetings include a focus on topics such as Pacific Islander services, Koorie services, networks to support people out of squalor and hoarding and domestic violence. There are many more others that keep the service system well connected. We wonder whether bringing these networks together with Family by Family Sharing Families could strengthen the system and better link families to all the services they need?



Focus on security We found that many services appear to be very security conscious, as many have barred windows and fences that enclosed the service and small service windows, including safety screens for people to communicate through. We wondered what this is like for families?

Openness to all people works better Services that were open to all people had more people using them. One example was an Aboriginal specific service that had a welcoming space where, **“people are there from all different tribes.”** People are welcome to participate in activities, but are also welcome to find peace within themselves, as they said, there is, **“no forceability.”** One woman who attended said, **“I need this group, if not I’d be in a mental house or drunk in a park somewhere.”**

In another service, it is one of their primary goals to serve all people saying, **“no one goes away empty handed”**. Also at a local pool they have arranged a ‘family credit payment system’, marketed as ‘feeling the pinch during these hard and uncertain times?’ One service provides a specialised service for whole of family where they will work with families at different life stages.

Learning central to the community & services Of particular note appears to be the strong role that the local TAFE plays in the lives of families and services. Many families have members that are involved in TAFE and students are a resource for the community and appear to be an essential part of the service fabric.

Opportunities

Could Family by Family contribute to this strong service network by connecting them with Sharing Families to complement the support of families, and help increase outputs and outcomes for other service providers?

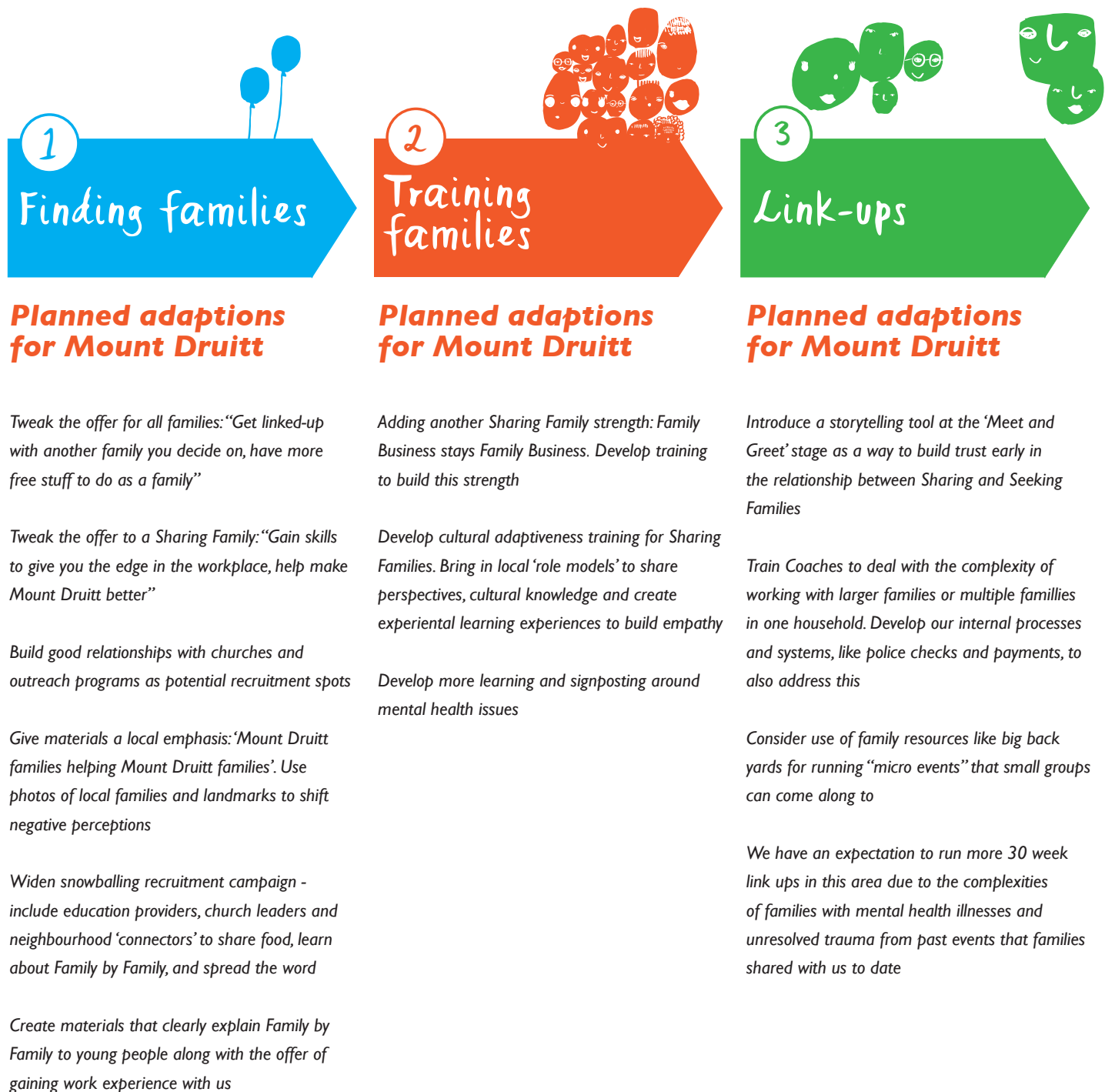
There is no doubt that security is an issue, is there another way to do this without creating such an obvious separation between services and families?

Could TAFE offer an opportunity for Family by Family to recruit Sharing Families?

Could Family by Family also provide an opportunity for TAFE students to learn more about the community services field?

Question 5:

How can we best adapt family by family for Mount Druitt?

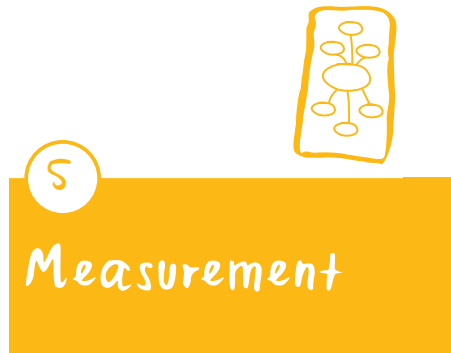




Planned adaption for Mount Druitt

Test whether the Team Coaching model will work with Indigenous families, some of whom shared their concern of sharing 'family business' with others

Understand the implications for our Kid's Coach role and whether there will be a need to employ more given the larger numbers of children per family



Planned adaption for Mount Druitt

None yet



Planned adaption for Mount Druitt

Include education providers like TAFE, church leaders and local connectors in interactions like our service lunches and shadows

FAMILY BY family a new model for Mount Druitt

After considering all the opportunities thrown up by the scoping project, the diagram opposite show the adaptations we plan to make to the model in Mount Druitt.

The scoping process is extremely valuable. Family life is different everywhere and being able to experience that through the eyes of families, and work out with them what needs to be redesigned, in order to have a higher likelihood of engaging families and creating change in that context is key.

There are also some opportunities that we won't immediately pursue because of resource and time constraints but we hope to explore them going forward.

Questions we still have ...
Is there a possibility to create new roles for grand parents?
Is there a role in Family by Family for parents who currently don't have their children with them?
How can we contribute to shaping local policy & practice so there are more opportunities for whole families?
How can Family by Family create change for more families by using Cultural Consultants?

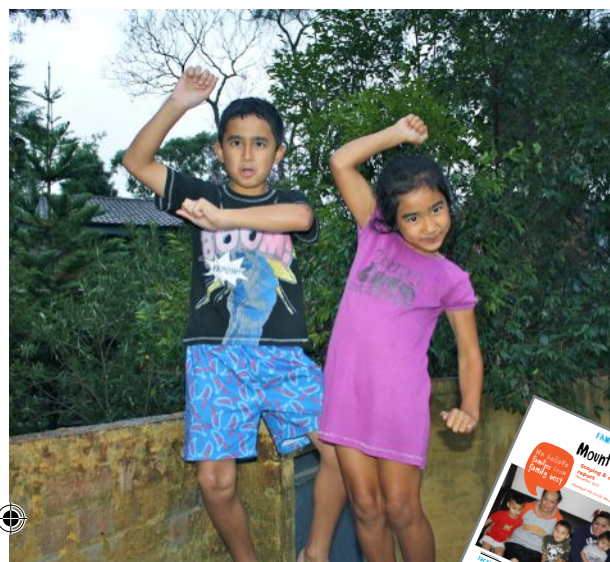
Start-up in Mount Drvitt

Where we're at ...

December

January

February



Mount Drvitt Scoping Report

Completed

Sounding Board

First meeting completed

Recruiting Sharing Families

Some already identified from our scoping.

New Sharing Family recruitment materials developed

Training Sharing Families

Development of additional Sharing Family Strength

One camp completed, start planning for the next one

Recruiting Seeking Families

Continue to make connections and build relationships with organisations for referrals and recruitment

Link-ups and Team Coaching

Develop additional materials to support Team Coaching model

March



Sounding Board

Next meeting: 2nd March 2014

Thoughts from the team

What came as no surprise during the scoping process was the high interest we had from families to get involved and share their story.

This was due to our set of innovative tools and designed interactions established through the work at TACSI.

Some examples of how we differ from traditional service delivery include:

Having families identify their own strengths and lead this process, opposed to a worker identifying the strengths they notice.

Making all interactions feel friendly and informal by doing things like sharing a meal.

Including the whole family, giving a voice to children and making sure we visit the family home at a time that they will be around, even if it is 7.30am or 9pm.

*Using tools such as our stress cards or service cards instead of traditional referral forms or survey sheets. One of our new Coaches even said, **"I've worked with that family for 3 years and I just learnt more about them in 2 hours."***

Producing this scoping report after families have helped us develop our direction, opposed to having families consult on something already written. Scoping in this way takes consultation to a whole new level.

Localisation strategy

How can we play a part?

The NSW Department of Family and Community Services has created 15 Districts with the main aim to, "enable more localised planning and decision-making and improve links between senior service delivery management and frontline staff"¹ with a strong partnership with the NGO sector. Family by Family, through this scoping process, has met community groups and services and found there to be a vibrant and highly connected system of services.

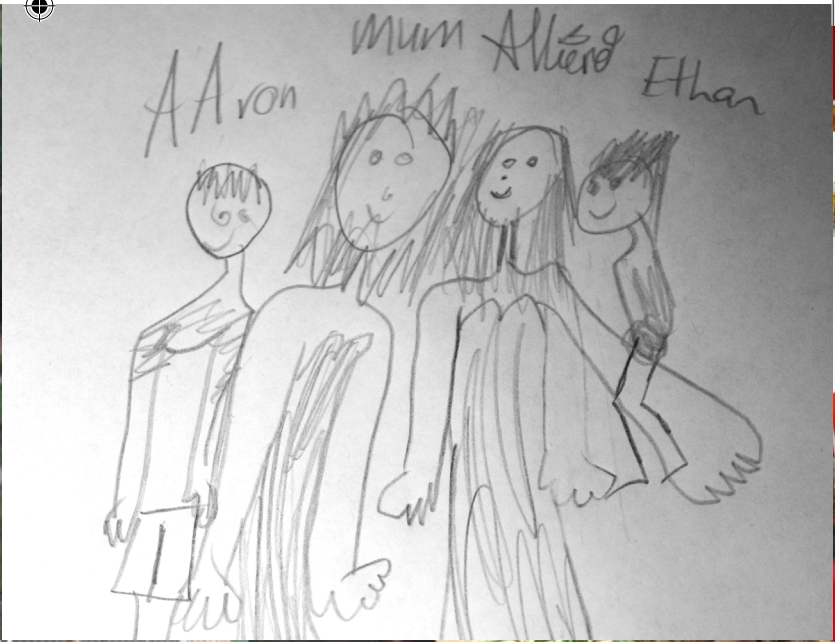
This strategy has a focus on person centred care that provides services that are, "flexible, integrated and tailored to individual circumstances and local needs,"² and to support the person at the centre of decision making when it comes to the services they use.

Family by Family has contributed to this vision through meeting with families, and directly asking them about their home, lives, what they're good at, tough times and aspirations over meals or whole days in their lives.

We've used tools to do this including local maps where families can tell us the places they love and the places that concern them. We ask about the services they know and who is around to support them - all of this to keep families at the centre of what we do.

¹ FACS Localisation - Background

² FACS Stakeholder 2013-14 Budget Briefing, 18 June 2013





Family
details
anonymised

More from
the families
and the team...

Dani

Having worked for Family by Family for the past 2 and ½ years, of course I have a good understanding of the importance of working with local people to produce local outcomes.

However the move to Mount Druitt has demonstrated to me on a new level the importance of having local staff to roll this work out. I truly believe had we not had staff who not only had worked but lived in the local area, families would not have been as receptive to this program as they have been.

Families need to know they're being supported by someone who gets where they're coming from. From people who hold the non-verbal knowing which is their community.

Angela

I've worked in Mount Druitt for 11 years and have lived in the area raising my family for 24 years. After all that time, I thought I knew the Mount Druitt community pretty well, but I'd only skimmed the surface understanding what family life and the area is like. We have been on a mission to learn about this in scoping. We've spent time with families in their homes, getting to know them, and have used different tools to dig deeper.

I met with a family I had previously worked with for 3 years, and I must say I now know more about them all after spending a few hours with them using these tools during scoping, than I did in all the years before. Families told us they are excited about Family by Family and many of them want to be involved as either Seeking or Sharing Families.

We spent time with lots of services too - finding out about what they provide for families, what works for them, and what they struggle with. It has been great learning from them, and we really appreciate the support they have shown us. And this is only the beginning and we can't wait to keep working with them.

The families were so open and honest. I think because we didn't go in telling families what is wrong with them, or what they need to fix, instead we were looking for what was important to them and their ideas, it made a big difference. Many families commented: "you're the only one who has ever asked what would work for my family."

Julie

Living in the western suburbs and working in the local area with troubled youth allowed me to gain an understanding of their family relationships, or in a lot of cases, a lack of family relationships. Learning about their upbringing was often sad and challenging.

I learned one of the reasons many young people found themselves caught up in the service 'net' such as DOC's or the criminal justice system, was not because parents didn't care, it was because their parents struggled to cope, and found the responsibility of caring overwhelming. If there had been support for the whole family in the beginning, would these children be thriving and sleeping in their own beds now?

It has been an honour meeting families of different sizes, cultures and race, sharing a meal together and not only getting to know what's tough for families but what makes these families 'family'. The scoping tools used means that a lot of thinking, laughing and honesty shines. I found a big difference between Family by Family and other services is that families are given a voice, no big forms or invasive questions, they share the stories they want to share.

Being out meeting families is great, and being invited into their homes to share a meal is a privilege! When I look back at those troubled youths, I believe Family by Family could have made a difference, not only their lives, but their whole family's lives. Going forward, I am excited to know that I am part of a team that can help bring change to families like them.

The team





A ten year old boy teaches
us about his family.

The Fraser Family



Sal had forgotten we were coming over - she tells us later she was half out her head on medication when she first met someone from Family by Family and has no idea who she spoke to. This is due to her recent hospital visit - the result of a necrotic tattoo she has had removed. There's now a skin graft in its place that hasn't yet healed despite surgery in April.

About the family

Sal describes herself as born and bred country, bipolar, an insomniac, a recluse, and having multiple personalities: **"You never know what you're going to get when you come see me. You don't know if you get me or Tom, Dick or Harry down the road."** We're told we have her on a good day and that she wouldn't have let us in otherwise. She feels she currently has control of her mental illnesses and no longer medicates.

She describes having a number of fears - getting public transport, open spaces, closed spaces and eating in front of people, but her biggest fear is people. She laughs nervously a lot and re-enacts aggressive conversations with people when sharing stories about past events. We're told she used to be a lot larger and people now don't recognise her. She shares her home with 4 dogs - mostly ones she has rescued, plus 2 rescued cats, and throughout our conversation they intermittently bark or whimper from outside.

Sal's daughter Juliet, just over 2 years old, is asleep in bed initially. She wakes during our visit and is fetched to eat her KFC and play with us. Sal makes a number of references to her size - in her words of 'an average 4 year old'. We wonder whether this is because of criticism she experienced about her weight in the past, and she's quick to point out this isn't due to feeding her junk food. Sal describes Juliet as speech delayed, and as being 'slow to start off with'. She tells us later: **"I'm a bitch. My daughter is going to grow up to be a bitch too, but a bitch with balls. Not get walked all over like her mother did."**

What's home like?

Sal asks us to excuse the mess. The house has a stale odour with a couple of empty drink cartons and used wrappers around the floor, along with recent stains on the carpet. We later find out this is because her dogs were left to fend for themselves during the recent hospital visit. It feels like the television is never turned off and it stays on during our time there. There is one doll lying on the floor underneath the TV cabinet.

Sal has lived in the area for 4 years. She moved here permanently when Juliet was 4 months old and was initially homeless, despite support from local MP's and NGO's. She has moved house about 22 times in this time. She has been on the housing list for 8 years and currently rents privately but is paying beyond her means (at \$700 a fortnight) and is in rent arrears.

Sal states she doesn't go out. For her walking out the front door is a big effort and she worries she is getting too withdrawn from the population. She tells us she sometimes goes to the park over the road with her partner and daughter which is about a five minute walk away. She also walks 45 minutes at least once a week to get to a local support group.

Despite her fears, she doesn't have an issue with areas of Mount Druitt. For her, it's about the wrong people, not places. She was able to identify a church in Wilmott that helps out with food and is good with families, but couldn't tell us about a time she used it. Apart from the one support group, she says groups are not for her, and even if she knows people are in the same situation that she is, in her mind they are still people she doesn't know, and that is what is most scary for her.

Who's around and who is helpful?

Sal has few support networks. She indicates fractured relations with her family (sisters and father - one sister has care of her two older children) who don't live locally - they are in the country and on the central coast. She tells us she doesn't have many friends. Her belief is she loses them because they don't like being told the truth, and she talks 'straight up' which gets her into trouble.

She met her partner through an adult match making website 3 years ago and he is the father of Juliet. She describes their relationship as open. They don't live together because, in her words, if they did they 'would kill each other'. She talks about pushing his buttons when they first met that led to him hitting her. She says the relationship has its ups and downs, but she wants it to continue. She is proud that all her children are currently in contact with their fathers.

Sal could identify a lot of services and groups in the area, but hadn't used them. Despite not being with her two older children, she describes limited contact with DOCs. She talks about a disgruntled person who once called them and informed them she was on the drug ICE, but tells us how this was a lie, and how she told them to come around and see she has nothing to hide.

She tells us a time she did use a local NGO once, but in desperation when she was moving, and having no money, approached them in tears for help. There's a sense that service use is seen as failure perhaps, or that fear of the unknown and having to engage with people causes anxiety. She states: **"I don't reach out because a lot of people have been through a lot worse off than me."**

Interests, capabilities and values

When asked to describe her typical routine, Sal just focuses on the basics of 'wake up, walk, sleep, bath, feed, bed' and in terms of looking after Juliet. There is little to indicate a space to think or work on goals or aspirations.

Sal likes craft and is making things for the support group she attends. She gets pleasure about the fact that people in need will be getting value from this.

Sal shared more about her lack of capabilities. She would like to work, and did get a job before she fell ill, but feels like she wouldn't be able to afford childcare if she worked now anyway - **"I'm damned if I do, damned if I don't."**

What's tough?

Living with mental illness is tough on Sal. She describes it as being constantly on alert and that her head 'never stops'. She shares with us sometimes she fears that she may hurt someone if she goes 'over the edge' and that her awareness of the damage that she can cause is difficult to live with.

It's frustrating for Sal that in her opinion all people see is her emotions, and not her awareness of her own rationality or irrationality. She talks of particular frustration at sometimes needing to get someone 'normal' to talk on her behalf to get professionals (doctors in this case) to listen to her needs, even though the 'normal person is saying the exact same things she is.

Sal believes she is stressed 24 hours a day. When asked to pick out her top 3 stress cards, she laughs and says 'you're hilarious'. She describes them as all linked in together - stress is always present and something she sees as never stopping.

Sal states that her mental illness caused her to lose control 4 years ago. Because of her realisation that her children (at that time) could have been in danger, she handed them to her family and disappeared to ensure they stayed safe.

She tells us she's getting compensation for four different events from her past. She tells us she doesn't want the money herself, but thinks her daughter deserves to live better than they do currently.

Money is a big issue for Sal. She struggles to survive on \$50 a fortnight for food and tells us she often goes hungry to provide for her daughter. Her partner helps out with a monthly shop, and if it wasn't for that, she thinks she wouldn't be able to cope.

Sal thinks her housing situation is 'bullshit'. She feels resentment that people from **"overseas and immigrants seem to be here for 20 seconds and get a place"** whereas she believes the same opportunities aren't available to her.

Family Motto - 'If shit attracted flies, I'd be in trouble'

As a single parent, Sal plays all roles in her family and initially laughs and says her partner's role is just for sex. She then goes on to describe him as someone who knows how to get her 'off her arse' and how just his presence has the ability to calm her in times of bad stress and confusion. They have also found a way to argue without raising their voices, as this scares Juliet.

Family by Family

Sal likes the idea of Family by Family and agrees with the values and principles in the statements offered. She recognises that there is a gap in her daughter's ability to socialise with others and would welcome more opportunities for this. She also sees that her daughter gets affected by her emotions and would like to think she could counter this somehow.

Currently the weekly playgroup trip is their only public event. Events and groups frighten her though, but she says she would try and get to them if her health allowed. When talking about Link ups, she tells us she wouldn't like someone judging her, telling her what to do, and particularly if she thought they weren't listening to her. Trust is a big issue for Sal.

Some weeks she feels like she shouldn't have a child, but then states 'my life is my kid'. She would welcome more adult conversation though, instead of **"Yeah, wonderful, two year old conversation 24 hours a day."**

The Miller Family



I arrive at Veronica's door at 9am, and I'm told to come in from inside the screen door. She is shyly standing putting dishes away and I get the feeling she's dressed up for my visit - she looks immaculate. I tell her I'm here to learn about her family life. She looks pleased and nervous, her shoulders are slumped forward. With some gentle questioning, she tells me she's had a rough life.

About the family

Veronica is 48 years old and childlike in some of her mannerisms and responses. She has a big, beautiful smile. She's white Australian and originally from Orange but has lived in Blackett for the last 5 or 6 years. She likes it better here. She has four children to four fathers - a 30 year old, a 27 year old, 17 year old and a 11 year old. She lives with one of them - Aaron (aged 11). During the day she's reluctant to talk about her other children, and I only get the names of two of them. She struggles and can't remember the names of her two grandchildren.

She describes growing up as pretty hard. With 3 'cruel' sisters, a mother who didn't want her, and a step father who put her in a home at the age of 9 - she calls it a 'spastic school' and later a 'mental house'. She didn't like it much. She can't read or write, but can print her name perfectly through practice. Her son Aaron does all her reading for her, including inputting her PIN number at the ATM, and reading out letters from school informing her of his bad behaviour.

She's been married twice. Her most recent husband broke her nose and went with two other woman. He kidnapped Aaron when he was a baby, but Veronica got him back eventually. She worries he'll do it again but tells me she's got a stable home and food now. Her second husband shot her with a 30:30. It missed her by an inch. She feels wary of men.

What's home like?

The house is dark, cool and clean. There are numerous knick knacks displayed. Cabinets along the walls are adorned with stuffed toys, dried flowers, ceramic clowns, photos and angels. Angels are the most important, and she believes they are always watching her. Two well worn armchairs and a sofa face a television that is always on. This is where Veronica spends most of her days.

There are a few signs of an 11 year old son living there - a coloured in name and a chore chart stuck to a cupboard and appearances in photo's - one with a famous race car driver, one with santa, and one more recent with a broken leg from an accident.

She tells me there's a huge back yard but she doesn't go out there. There's a calendar with big X's drawn on every day. I ask her what she's counting down towards, but there's nothing - she just marks the days off every day.

What are routines like?

Every day starts with getting up, Aaron gets dressed, and sometimes he has breakfast, or he gets it at the school. She walks him there, **"all the way down, all the way back. Even in the rain, but no one ever stops to pick us up."** It's a 5 minute walk away.

Most days are the same for Veronica, 'normal' - in the home cleaning up - there's the bathroom to do and making Aaron's bed, she likes to get it out the way and not worry about it later. She loves the television, the midday movie and Home and Away. I'm told a friend pops in **"once in a blue moon"**. Aaron gets back around 3:30pm, eats in his room and plays playstation. His bedtime is at 7:30pm.

She gets 'paid' (benefits) on a Saturday and sometimes they go to Mount Druitt shopping or catch a bus to St. Marys (for more shops). Mostly they sit at home and watch TV. She says it gets boring. And yet she also sees herself as getting no time to herself, **"It's all about Aaron. I've got to look after him. I do it on my own. Nobody will help you"**.

I ask if Christmas will be different? But she says no, they will be on their own and no one comes. It's hard as Aaron would love to go and visit family in Orange, but Veronica's rent and bills mean they can't afford it. She's paying off \$600 for a second hand cooker but states: **"I'll get there, get by"**.

I learn she goes to a group for lunch sometimes once a week. She's learned a bit about her family history there. I ask if she'd like to go to more groups, and she says it would be **"unreal"**. I ask how she found out about the one she goes to, and a man she knows took her there. I tell her about the community breakfast in Bidwill on Tuesday, but she says that's a fair way away for her.

Who's around and who's helpful

Veronica rents from the housing commission. It was originally emergency housing. She says it's a pretty quiet street. Sometimes she gets scared and wishes she had a dog, to bark and even bite to keep people away. That said there are no areas she avoids, and she likes where she lives, including her neighbours, but she doesn't know their names.

I ask if she had contact with services, but she says 'nothing like that'. I know she's on a pension so I don't think I'm asking the right question. I try a few different ways but she still says no. She tells me she's had nothing much to do with DOCs.

What's tough?

Veronica talks about her children as sources of stress, her biggest being Aaron. She says **"He's unbelievable, back chats me, gives me mouth and cheek and tells me to 'get f**ked'"**. She says she has tried everything, including sending him to his room, threatening him with a stick, threatening to take him to the police station to have a talking to, and telling him that in high school he'll get his head flushed down the toilet if he 'doesn't grow up and get a brain'. She says he'll say he'll be good, but then does the same things again. She wants to send him to a bootcamp, **"one of those things on the TV where they go and come back good kids."** She says he takes it out of her and she sometimes needs a break.

She shows his homework book. It's a set of worksheets that parents are supposed to go through with their children. There are many all filled in neatly, but the more recent ones are untouched. Veronica is perplexed that the teacher doesn't mark them, and that Aaron's told, **"get your mum to help you."** She says, **"I try a little bit. But it's different how they teach them these days. We learnt the old way. They don't teach kids right."** Reading through them, it's pretty complex stuff even if you can read - spelling, fractions, percentages, converting roman numerals, underlining complex verbs. There is a homework club run locally but Aaron doesn't go. She would like him to play outside more rather than just staying in his room.

One of her older sons also comes down occasionally and in her words, **"runs amuck and gets me in trouble. Causes a racket because he's got a big mouth and doesn't learn to keep it shut."**

What do they want from their lives?

Veronica has never been on holiday or to another state. If she could wave a magic wand, she would learn to read so she could get her licence. She could go anywhere then. She's tried to learn before, but it hasn't happened. She'd like to give up smoking too. She tries to stick to goals but fails, **"I muck it up again."**

She says, **"you know what I'd like to do? Someone to teach me to dance. I reckon that would be awesome. Or like on the TV where they give you a makeover. I like that idea. I've never had a pamper and that."**

Her idea of what makes a good family is one that, **"sits together and does stuff. Go out places and things like that. Instead of being stuck at home all the time"**. She'd go to the zoo if she had the money (she think there's one in Doonside). She thinks the idea of meeting other parents with different strategies would be good, but doesn't think she could offer anything in return.

The Walford Family



Lucy knocked on our door on Friday evening. **“Are you that Family by Family mob?”** she asks. She walks through our door and immediately starts to cry.

About the family

Lucy is an Aboriginal woman who finds family life complicated. She is a mother of 5 children and lives in Tregear. Earlier in her life she had been married to a well respected man who was violent towards her.

Lucy felt like she needed to leave and left her children with carers while she went bush to clear her head. Lucy tells me, **“while I was away I learnt how to shear and slaughter a sheep, after that I could come home. I felt confident that no one would try to smack me again cos I knew how to slaughter them.”**

What’s home like?

Lucy shares her home with her children, boarders and grandchildren. Her house is considered a safe place within this community and it is not uncommon for people to drop by. Although she grew up here, she often feels out of place, and so comes and goes from the area when times get tough. Sometimes she feels out of control of her relationships.

Although the family are finding clever ways to make crowded conditions work, it is obvious that they struggle to make ends meet, and share how they are saving up to buy a fridge. Lucy is trying to do her best to keep her family strong, but tells us this has become harder lately with lots of ‘freeloaders’ dropping by to hang out with her children.

Who’s around and who is helpful?

Lucy knows about Aboriginal women’s groups that she can access for support, but finds it hard to fit in. She also feels excluded by some members of her own community and longs to have a cup of tea with someone, **“I bet they are all there now having a nice cup of tea together! Again no one invited me.”**

We suggest other groups we have heard of, but she doesn’t want to attend those groups due to tensions. Lucy admits to us that she often ends up at the groups for men because she is more accepted there.

What’s tough?

Today has been a tough day for Lucy. Her daughter struggles with her mental health. It is not uncommon for her daughter to experience psychosis and this can be especially stressful for the family.

Lucy tells us that earlier in the week her daughter had wandered into the community while experiencing this. She would love to take her daughter on a holiday to help her clear her mind, to get away from their house and to have some more time to connect with each other.

Feeling judged is stressful for Lucy. She says **“I need to have my community help me raise my children, instead of just looking on and telling me that I’m not coping. Stop judging my backyard! We are all involved in one big backyard.”**

Family by Family

Lucy shared her ideas about how Family by Family could work with Aboriginal families.

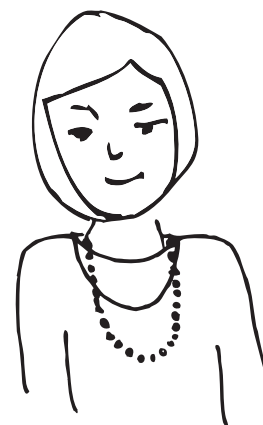
She thinks being explicit around the statement ‘feel free not to share family business’ would help. For her it’s important she feels able to build trust, before she shares anything personal.

She thinks the offer of practical help would really be helpful for her situation. Things like: **“can I help you get to the shops in my car? ‘or ‘I need a hand to look after the kids’.”**

Another idea was around supporting a different family a month. She thought this could work by having a whole network of families pitching in together for a month at a time to support one particular family in need.

Finally, she saw benefits in separating the learning of children from the learning of adults, by following what she named ‘the 3 L rule’, **“For children, help teach them how to LOOK, LISTEN and LEARN. For adults, teach them how things relate to LAND, LAW and LANGUAGE. These are Aboriginal families biggest obstacles and biggest opportunities.”**

The Mosley Family



About the family

Family life has never been easy for Leanne, she was born to a prostitute in London to a Maltese father. When she was a baby, her father discovered her mother passed out due to drugs, with Leanne in her arms and her head flopping on the floor. He immediately took her and sent her to live with his parents in Malta who brought her up until she was aged 3.

Leanne's father and his new wife then moved to Australia to start a new life. Leanne's grandparents insisted that she also join the family. This was hard for Leanne as she spoke little English and could not communicate with her step mother. Leanne felt like her step mother didn't love her.

At 14, Leanne was kicked out of the family home and found herself on the streets. The police returned her several times, but as soon as they left, she would be kicked out again.

Leanne turned to solicitation as a way to survive: **"You learn how to become numb."** She also started taking drugs to help her cope, starting with dope then moving on to cocaine, and she began a relationship with her dealer. The couple got married and had three children. During this relationship Leanne became addicted to the drug ICE. She tells us her husband became distant, and would often not come home for weeks at a time. When he did, he was violent - one time he broke her jaw which was left hanging for 3 weeks.

One day when she was 'off her face', Leanne realised she was no longer able to care for children, and so packed her kids in the car and drove them to her father's home. Leanne remembers this car drive being scary as the children screamed while she struggled to keep awake behind the wheel. When she pulled up in front of the family home, Leanne passed out. Three days later when she woke up, her children had been removed.

Who's around and who's helpful?

Leanne has a family friend Lisa who for years has offered to help out. Leanne had never called Lisa for help because she felt too embarrassed. Feeling like she had nothing else to lose and no one else, she rang Lisa. Lisa put Leanne up in her family home, a modern house in Rooty Hill, and this is where she now lives.

What do they want for their lives?

With Lisa's support, Leanne has got herself clean, started setting goals, and is actively trying to better her life with the hope that she can have her children restored. Now her focus is on being a good Mum.

She is volunteering with local groups to gain more skills, and has started studying Community Services. She makes sure that she attends Drug and Alcohol groups twice a week. She has also started saving for a house of her own. She tells us **"I'm so proud of myself now."**

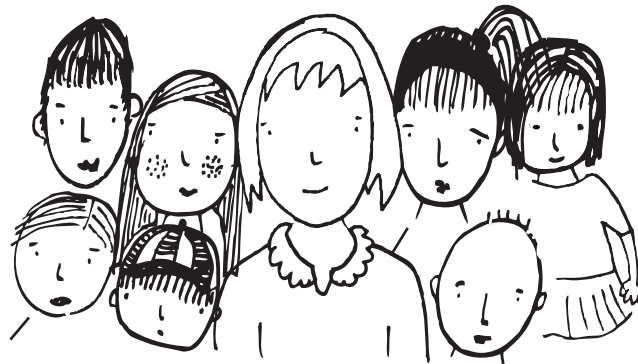
Leanne's experience has given her a strong desire to help others saying, **"I am very knowledgeable and I can help others, but for some reason I wasn't able to help myself."**

Family by Family

Leanne is excited by the program, saying that it could have helped her family. She thinks more people should know about it and gives us a list of suggestions on where we should advertise.

The idea that the family helping had been through tough times and come out of the other side was very appealing. She thought they would 'get it' and understand how hard life can be. She also felt they would therefore not judge the person they were helping.

The Tapinahu Family



About the family

Olina is a Pacific Islander. She came here from New Zealand 7 years ago and lives with her 7 children with ages between 19 and 2. Ada, her oldest daughter (aged 19) is looking to find work, 'doing anything', but tells us it's really difficult. Next week she'll take part in a free 2 day barista training which she hopes will lead somewhere. Olina's partner left some years ago but is now back on the scene and wants to work things out and make amends. Olina wishes he'd **"grow up."**

What's home like?

Olina's 4 bedroomed home is in Tregear. Their house is sparsely furnished and doesn't reveal much character about the family - save one picture of Jesus. Olina tells us they arrived with nothing, and a local church helped them set up. It's owned by the housing commission (who she found very helpful) and we're told it has a big backyard.

Who's around & who's helpful?

When Olina first moved to the area, she didn't like it much, but thought, **"suck it up, you've just got to accept it, you have a roof over your head, you're not on the road."** Generally now she thinks it's not a bad area. She sees others as doing the best they can, but thinks what gets in the way is that they don't know where to go to get help and support with their needs.

She only has one friend who lives locally, 'a fellow Kiwi', the rest of her friends are back in New Zealand. She describes herself as cautious of mixing with people here, due to a few early instances of being burnt by people, **"nice to the face, but different once your back is turned."** The school has been a good spot for meeting people.

Olina doesn't find any suburb stressful. She's read in the paper about stabbings in Tregear, and thinks that alcohol plays a big part in the bad reputation of Bidwill. She thinks most bad things happen when alcohol is involved and is perplexed by the Council allowing this to happen in social functions at the community centres there. She puts it down to the fact that there's nothing to do here, **"it's too far out where we are and people have no place to go."**

This family likes to go to the parks, and they usually go over to the ones at Ropes Crossing which are much nicer, as the local ones have needles and bottles lying around. They've never tried the community centre at Ropes Crossing though.

She tried to attend the local church and believes she got rejected, they pointed her in the direction of the nearest Cook Island Church instead. She thinks they were trying to be thoughtful. She has an interesting relationship with God. She's a believer, but feels hypocritical sitting in church when aspects of her life are 'not right' and she's **"not fully living God's way."** She also gets embarrassed by her children's behaviour if they start to misbehave there.

We ask Ada about what young people do in the area, but she says there is nothing. Olina indicates she would like Ada to be involved in Headspace, and says it would be useful for getting new connections to support her in efforts to find work.

Olina didn't finish high school and thinks that this is now a barrier to her getting a job. It's important for her that her children get the most out of the education system here. Her two youngest sons used to go to pre-school, but they had to give it up when they could no longer afford it.

The family enjoy going to the local leisure centre, as it's much more affordable than things like the movies, and the children enjoy it. A local NGO helped her with dealing with her separation. She has used job agencies, but thinks that the lack of jobs is an main issue.

When we asked about using DOCs, she laughs and says, **"We've been there, but not for services. When housing were helping us, they sent us to DOCs, but DOCs told housing to take us back. Housing was trying to pass the buck but DOCs said 'hey, you can't bring this family here.'"**

When Olina split with her partner, she found a 'parenting after separation' program that helped her a lot, to overcome the resentment she felt, and see things from her partner's perspective. For her family, life is good when everyone is involved. While she found life stressful at first following her break up, once the family worked together, things got better.

Olina and Ada have helped out with a local community program run by the community hall - she tells us she is happy to help where she can. This program was about helping families through the bartering of food for time on projects like weeding gardens and fundraising. Now this program has moved outside the area, she can no longer take part as she can't afford to travel to them. She thinks other programs are offered at the hall, so she might go down and have a look eventually. However she shares her frustration that her daughter recently offered to help out there at a free meals program, in order to gain some skills as a volunteer, but was turned away because she wasn't 'work for the dole or Newstart'.

What's tough?

Money is this family's biggest stress. Olina doesn't get the full benefits and it's a struggle to get by. She says they, "make do with what we have", but it sometimes feels like they are barely surviving, particularly when things crop up unexpectedly, like recently when the car broke down, or needing to find money for a school excursion.

Finding work is also really hard for both herself and Ada. One of them needs to work while the other will need to look after the children. Olina feels sorry that she needs to put Ada in this position. She says the children often play up when left in Ada's care, and that this is stressful for her.

Food is another big worry. It's difficult to feed a family of 7 with their money worries. They do have a few tricks up their sleeves, such as shopping at Aldi, and finding the specials, and buying these instead.

The final stresses for Olina were family and children. She tells us that sometimes the children's behaviour fluctuates and this takes its toll on everyone. She puts this down to the situation she is in with her partner and the fact they are playing a 'waiting game' for the father to make a decision about what he wants to do with his life. She doesn't want the children to live in false expectations or intentions, or to return to the difficulties they had before. She thinks the children can see she is not stable and therefore play up. She tells us that her eldest son has behaviour issues at school and struggles to express his emotions. She has tried to suggest to him that writing down his feelings might help, or if he can't share them with her, then to talk to one of his siblings.

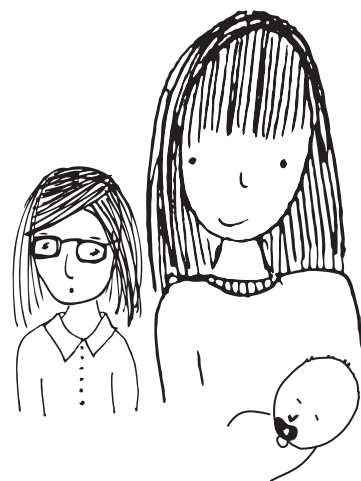
What does they want for their lives?

Finding work is a goal for both Olina and Ada. One of them needs to work while the other will need to look after the children. Olina feels sorry that she needs to put Ada in this position. She says the children often play up when left in Ada's care, and that this is stressful for her.

Family by Family

The idea of being part of a network of families and helping out others was really appealing for this family, and Olina liked the idea of remuneration with the possibility of becoming a Sharing Family eventually, but said: ***"I like it for what the program is offering, not for the money."***

The Rangi Family



About the family

Patrice is a 28 year old single mum with a 4 year old son, Kaleb. She is one week away from giving birth. Patrice was born in Brisbane to Maori parents.

What's home like?

Patrice and Kaleb live in an unassuming four bedroom home. The walls were painted green and there are a lot of New Zealand themed items in the lounge - a New Zealand velvet wall hanging, a black and white beanbag that has 'New Zealand' printed all over it, and a green and black table runner with Maori designs on it, and Kaleb's jumper has 'Aotearoa' printed on the front of it. It has an inviting, calm feel about it.

Patrice's routine changes daily depending on whether Kaleb is at pre-school or at home. Patrice and Kaleb have a busy schedule during the week - including pre-school, swimming lessons and visits to Patrice's Mum. On Wednesday's while Kaleb is at pre-school, Patrice attends a local women's support group.

Who's around & who's helpful?

Patrice appears to be very close to her mother and siblings. Her Mum will be looking after Kaleb when Patrice goes into hospital to give birth. Patrice told us she has a number of friends in the Mount Druitt area.

Patrice told us that Kaleb has recently been diagnosed with autism. Patrice tells us she was in denial for a long time about Kaleb's condition before seeking help. She mentioned that she'd recently been diagnosed with gestational diabetes and was managing her condition by keeping tabs on her diet.

Patrice told us she used to be a foster mum to a young girl before she had Kaleb, and would attend the PCYC on a regular basis whilst she was fostering. Patrice and Kaleb go to their local church.

What's tough?

When we talked with Patrice about what stressed her, she picked out 'Money', 'Family worries' and 'Things to do'.

Patrice tells us she needs Centrelink payments get by. Patrice told us she currently receives the parenting payment, however since Kaleb has been diagnosed with autism she is waiting to receive a carer's payment too. Patrice tells us that it's tough to get by on Centrelink alone.

Patrice told us that since Kaleb's autism diagnosis she has found it difficult to find affordable activities for Kaleb to participate in. She strives to keep Kaleb active as she feels it helps with his autism.

What does they want for their lives?

Although Patrice appears to be in a good place at the moment, she mentioned that she is currently focused on living from day to day and would love to 'thrive'. Patrice's past job was working in the legal field and she also has two business administration certificates. Patrice mentioned that she would like to go back to work once her new baby was older.

Family by Family

Patrice really loved the idea of Family by Family. She told us she had been to the website and read some of the family's stories and that she was very interested in being a Sharing Family.

The Banks Family



About the family

Home is packed to the rafters for young couple Mandy and Jamie and their two children Sahara (aged 2) and Juliet (aged 6 months). They share with Jamie's parents, and his brother and sister in law who is due to give birth any day now. 9 people in total live in this home.

Who's around & who's helpful?

This home acts as its own mini community. When asked to name local friends or supports, Mandy struggles and tells us, **"the people I hang out with are the ones who live in this house."** She does, however enjoy taking part in a local Mum's group, and hopes one day she might run something similar herself.

Mandy enjoys making use of local facilities like the nearby gated park, and the free playground inside of Westfield shopping mall. She'd like to take her children to other family activities during the day, but finds them all too expensive.

What's tough?

Money is the biggest stress for this family, although sharing roles and responsibilities across the household works well. Having two children makes it particularly hard for Mandy to negotiate the supermarket, particularly needing to have a double trolley for the kids restricts her choices, and she hates the idea of catching public transport believing it's, **"dangerous on buses and trains."** They do have a car but Jamie takes this to his job as a carpenter apprentice, which leaves Mandy stuck at home most days.

Mandy talks to us about lack of time. The home was very organised and tidy, but she felt looking after this kept her away from spending time with her children. Digging deeper into her routine, she shared daily time allocated to watching movies and playing video games.

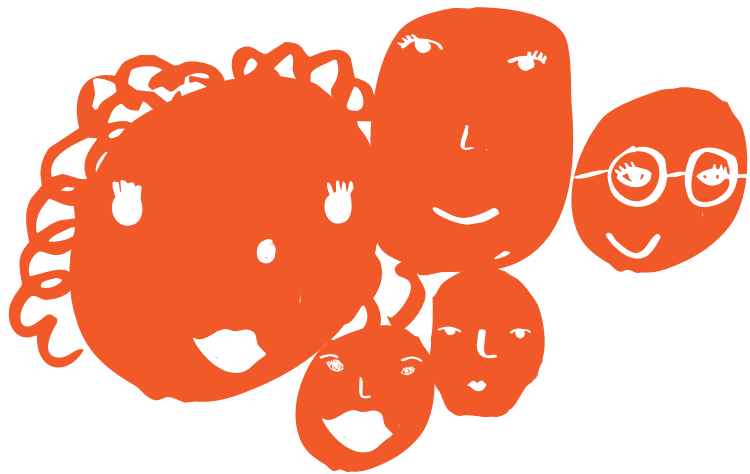
What do they want for their lives?

Mandy wants more children and for her and Jamie to live in a place of their own. They had been on the housing waiting list but Jamie's job meant they were means tested and are no longer eligible. Being a young couple they are finding it hard to get into the private rental market, because they have no prior history. She loves being a Mum, and is proud that Jamie has gotten himself a job he enjoys.



FAMILY BY family

Thanks so much to
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The Family by Family Team for this project were: Margaret Fraser, Sebastian Geers, Julie Hinder, Angela Jones, Danielle Madsen, Adele Liddle, Rhonda Scotney, Sandhya Sharma, Dana Shen & Chris Vanstone.

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